quadruple almost overnight, leading to massive protests against this hike. The two protests thus merged and were dubbed the Saffron Revolution, but to say that the monks were leading the revolution would be incorrect. The flames of these protests, dubbed as pro-democracy protests, were fanned by the West, with a number of 'white-skinned' people easily discernible in the crowds. Initially, the military junta did not do anything but allow the population to vent their feelings. The protests were absolutely peaceful with no arson or looting and no threat to safety, least of all to diplomatic missions. There was one incident of grenade-throwing outside the Chinese embassy, but nothing else. In fact, the processions used to go down Merchant Street and we would watch them go by from the office windows. On one occasion, I even made an approximate head count, which came to not more than a thousand or so, a far cry from the tens of thousands being reported in the Western media. It was only when the ranks of the protestors started getting infiltrated by Western agent provocateurs that the junta cracked down.

In fact, of all the countries, it was the Chinese who were the most worried, because anti-China sentiments run close to the surface, ready to break out. Ambassador Mitra, who had been posted to Myanmar earlier, recollected that he had seen Chinese getting 'slaughtered like rabbits' during some protests that had erupted in his previous tenure. While some embassies did issue travel advisories and such, for India and the Indian embassy, it was business as usual. While the protests were on, the junta had been making notes and taking videos of the protestors, so when they finally did decide to crack down, it did not take them long to round up the ringleaders among the protestors. There were a few incidents of firing, leading to several deaths, including six deaths in one single incident near Sule Pagoda in downtown Yangon, not far from the embassy.

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